Ranganathittu - September Bird Guide

Quick start

Real photographs + schematic field markers for a practical visit near Mysuru. Focused on the birds you are likely to notice from paths, islands and the boat route.

September approach

Scan the islands
Look for storks, ibis, spoonbill, herons and cormorants standing or nesting in trees.

Watch open water
Pelicans, cormorants and darters may be swimming; terns and kingfishers hunt over the surface.

Use silhouette first
Long neck + long legs = wader; dagger bill = fish hunter; huge pouch = pelican.

Flight matters
Herons fold the neck. Storks extend it. Terns have pointed wings and a forked tail.

Look for behaviour
Spoonbill sweeps its bill side-to-side; Pied Kingfisher hovers; darter often swims with only the neck obvious.

Seasonal caution
Exact numbers vary with water level, breeding activity and seasonal movements. Treat this as a likely-species guide, not a guaranteed checklist.

How to use each bird card

Each card has a **genuine Wikimedia Commons photograph** and a small **schematic marker sketch**. The sketch deliberately exaggerates the easiest field marks; always use the real photo for final confirmation.

Tall waders	Swimming divers	Fast aerial hunters	Banks / stones	Best habit
storks, ibis, spoonbill, herons	pelican, cormorant, darter	River Tern, Pied Kingfisher	Great Thick-knee	pause, scan slowly, then watch behaviour

Ranganathittu September Birds - Photo + Field Marks

Compact September guide for Ranganathittu near Mysuru. Genuine photographs plus schematic field markers, food, habits and where to look.

Painted Stork

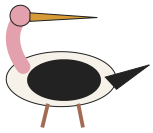
Large wader

Mycteria leucocephala



Photo: Raman Kumar | CC BY-SA 4.0 | Wikimedia Commons

ID MARKER SKETCH



- black-and-white wings
- pink tertials/rump
- long yellow-orange bill

ID: White stork with boldly black-and-white patterned wings, pink tertials, long yellow-orange downcurved bill and bare orange face.

Food: Fish, frogs and other small aquatic animals.

Habits: Walks through shallow water with bill partly open, sweeping it side to side and snapping shut on prey.

Look for: Shallows, exposed banks and nesting trees; often in loose groups.

Asian Openbill

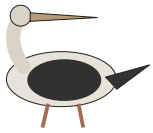
Large wader

Anastomus oscitans



Photo: J.M.Garg | CC BY-SA 3.0 | Wikimedia Commons

ID MARKER SKETCH



- distinct gap in bill
- dark flight feathers
- neck extended in flight

ID: Grey-white stork with black flight feathers and a distinctive gap between the closed mandibles of the bill.

Food: Mainly freshwater snails; also frogs and other aquatic prey.

Habits: Probes shallows and wet fields; the specialised bill helps handle snails.

Look for: Marshy edges, wet fields, shallow channels and communal roosts.

Spot-billed Pelican

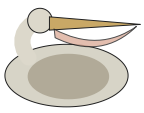
Very large waterbird

Pelecanus philippensis



Photo: Hari Krishnan | CC BY-SA 4.0 | Wikimedia Commons

ID MARKER SKETCH



- huge pouch + bill
- dark bill spots
- bulky grey-white waterbird

ID: Huge greyish pelican with a long pouch bill marked with dark spots; curly hind-crown feathers are often visible.

Food: Mostly fish.

Habits: Fishes from the surface, dipping the bill and pouch; often feeds and roosts socially.

Look for: Open river channels, broad pools and nesting trees on islands.

Black-headed Ibis

Large wader

Threskiornis melanocephalus



Photo: J.M.Garg | CC BY 3.0 | Wikimedia Commons

ID MARKER SKETCH



- bare black head/neck
- long down-curved bill
- clean white body

ID: White body, naked black head and neck, black legs and a long black downcurved bill.

Food: Insects, crustaceans, molluscs, frogs and small fish.

Habits: Walks steadily while probing soft mud and shallow water with the curved bill.

Look for: Mudflats, shallow margins, wet grass and quiet backwaters.

Ranganathittu September Birds - Photo + Field Marks

Compact September guide for Ranganathittu near Mysuru. Genuine photographs plus schematic field markers, food, habits and where to look.

Eurasian Spoonbill

Large wader

Platalea leucorodia



Photo: Macmohan | CC BY-SA 3.0 | Wikimedia Commons

ID MARKER SKETCH



- flat spoon-shaped bill
- all-white body
- feeds by sweeping bill

ID: Tall white bird with black legs and a long flat black bill ending in a broad spoon-shaped tip.

Food: Small fish, aquatic insects, crustaceans and tadpoles.

Habits: Sweeps the partly submerged bill rhythmically from side to side while walking.

Look for: Open shallows and calm margins where it has room to sweep-feed.

Oriental Darter

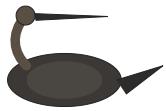
Large diving bird

Anhinga melanogaster



Photo: Charles J. Sharp | CC BY-SA 4.0 | Wikimedia Commons

ID MARKER SKETCH



- very long snake-like neck
- straight pointed bill
- silver-streaked wings

ID: Long snake-like neck, dagger bill and long tail; dark body with silvery streaks on the wings and back.

Food: Fish and other aquatic prey.

Habits: Swims low with only the neck showing, spears fish underwater, then often spreads wings to dry.

Look for: Quiet channels, low branches over water and exposed drying perches.

Indian Cormorant

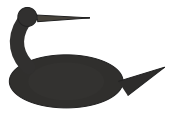
Medium-large diving bird

Phalacrocorax fuscicollis



Photo: Tisha Mukherjee | CC BY-SA 4.0 | Wikimedia Commons

ID MARKER SKETCH



- dark body
- hooked bill tip
- often dries wings spread

ID: Slim dark cormorant with a relatively long narrow bill, small peaked forehead and bright blue-green eye in good light.

Food: Fish, caught by underwater pursuit.

Habits: Dives repeatedly and may fish cooperatively; frequently sits with wings spread after feeding.

Look for: Open water, channels, snags and communal resting trees.

Grey Heron

Very large heron

Ardea cinerea

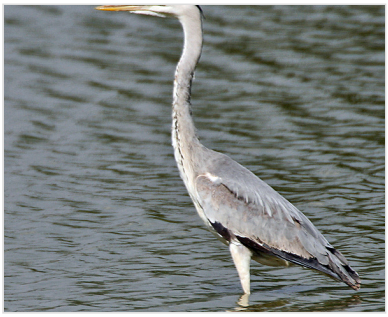


Photo: J.M.Garg | CC BY-SA 3.0 | Wikimedia Commons

ID MARKER SKETCH



- large grey body
- black head stripe/plumes
- neck folded in flight

ID: Tall grey-and-white heron with long yellowish bill, black head stripe and an S-shaped neck when at rest or flying.

Food: Fish, frogs, crabs, insects and small vertebrates.

Habits: Often stands motionless before striking rapidly with the bill; also stalks slowly.

Look for: Quiet banks, shallow pools, rocks and exposed river margins.

Ranganathittu September Birds - Photo + Field Marks

Compact September guide for Ranganathittu near Mysuru. Genuine photographs plus schematic field markers, food, habits and where to look.

Purple Heron

Very large heron

Ardea purpurea



Photo: Koshy Koshy from Faridabad, Haryana, India | CC BY 2.0 | Wikimedia Commons

ID MARKER SKETCH



- rufous striped neck
- slender dark grey-purple body
- often among reeds

ID: Slender, darker heron with chestnut-purple body tones, striped neck and a narrow snake-like profile.

Food: Fish, frogs, insects, reptiles and other small wetland prey.

Habits: Secretive; stalks through reeds and dense waterside vegetation rather than standing fully exposed.

Look for: Reedy, vegetated margins and shaded backwaters.

River Tern

Medium tern

Sterna aurantia



Photo: J.M.Garg | CC BY 3.0 | Wikimedia Commons

ID MARKER SKETCH



- black cap (breeding)
- yellow bill + red legs
- long pointed wings, forked tail

ID: Pale grey-and-white tern with long pointed wings, deeply forked tail and yellow bill; breeding adults show a black cap.

Food: Small fish, crustaceans and aquatic insects.

Habits: Flies buoyantly over water, then plunge-dives or dips to seize prey near the surface.

Look for: Open water, sandbars, rocks and stretches with active feeding flights.

Great Thick-knee

Large shorebird

Esacus recurvirostris



Photo: Charles J. Sharp | CC BY-SA 4.0 | Wikimedia Commons

ID MARKER SKETCH



- very large yellow eye
- bold black-white face
- heavy bill with yellow base

ID: Heavy brown-grey shorebird with huge yellow eye, bold black-and-white face pattern and a thick black-and-yellow bill.

Food: Crabs, insects, molluscs and other shoreline invertebrates.

Habits: Often rests quietly by day and becomes more active toward dusk; walks deliberately on banks.

Look for: Rocky or sandy river edges, exposed islands and undisturbed banks.

Pied Kingfisher

Medium kingfisher

Ceryle rudis



Photo: Charles J. Sharp | CC BY-SA 4.0 | Wikimedia Commons

ID MARKER SKETCH



- bold black-and-white
- shaggy crest
- hovers before plunge-diving

ID: Striking black-and-white kingfisher with shaggy crest; frequently hovers over water before diving.

Food: Mostly small fish; also aquatic invertebrates.

Habits: Hovers in one spot, folds its wings and plunges headfirst; often returns to an exposed perch.

Look for: Open river channels, poles, branches and wires close to water.